



# Mandarin -lǎo: A Case of Analytic Pejorativity

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## Overview

Evaluative morphology has been noted in generative linguistics since Scalise (1984). It expresses two dimensions of meaning, one objective, and one subjective (RITTER & WILTSCHKO 2023).

This paper studies the morphosyntax of the Mandarin pejorative suffix -lǎo (佬), glossed as PEJ, which is a case of evaluative morphology.

- -lǎo attaches to a stem and yields a noun;
- the noun typically denotes adult males (objective meaning, at issue) while carrying pejorative effects (subjective meaning, non-at issue), e.g. (1);
- While in some regions, -lǎo is neutral, we focus only on variants that have -lǎo as pejorative.

(1) X shì yí gè jī-lǎo.  
NAME COP one CL gay-PEJ  
At issue: 'X is a gay man.'  
Non-at issue: '(The speaker thinks that) gay people in general/ gayness is bad.'

## Properties of -lǎo

Morphosyntactic properties:

- -lǎo can attach to noun-, verb- or adjective-forming stems (2);
- yet -lǎo normally does not attach to occupation-denoting stems (3);
- -lǎo is always dependent — it cannot be used alone as a noun (4).

| (2) Stem <sub>(N/V/A)</sub> -lǎo | Gloss               | Translation                                 |
|----------------------------------|---------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| n <sup>1</sup> xiāngbā-lǎo       | countryside-PEJ     | (pej.) man from the countryside (hillbilly) |
| n <sup>2</sup> jīnróng-lǎo       | finance-PEJ         | (pej.) man in finance                       |
| v <sup>1</sup> [diào-yú]-lǎo     | [catch-fish]-PEJ    | (pej.) fisherman/ man who fishes a lot      |
| v <sup>2</sup> [hé-shì]-lǎo      | [mediate-thing]-PEJ | (pej.) peacemaker                           |
| a. féi-lǎo                       | fat-PEJ             | (pej.) fat man                              |

  

|                      |                  |                   |                |
|----------------------|------------------|-------------------|----------------|
| (3) a* [lǎo-shī]-lǎo | b* [gē-shǒu]-lǎo | c* [yī-shēng]-lǎo | (4) *yí gè lǎo |
| [NMLZ-teach]-PEJ     | [sing-NMLZ]-PEJ  | [cure-NMLZ]-PEJ   | one CL PEJ     |
| 'teacher'            | 'singer'         | 'doctor'          |                |

Semantic properties:

- the pejorative effects of -lǎo are unbounded (BEAVER & STANLEY 2022) (5);
- there is a separation of the pejorativity target and the resulting denotation of [X-lǎo];
- E.g., (2a) essentially expresses the speaker's negative opinions against *all fat people in general* and *fatness*, not just fat adult males; (2n<sup>2</sup>) disapproves *finance itself*, not just men in finance.

(5) #Wǒ cóngbù qíshì, dàn rúguǒ yǒu, nà wǒ bú huì hé nèi fat-lǎo wán.  
1SG never discriminate but if have, then 1SG NEG will with that fat-PEJ play  
# 'I have no discrimination, but if I did, I won't hang out with that fat-lǎo.'

## Analysis

Syntactic Structure

- We argue that -lǎo expones a pejorative nominaliser, denoted  $n_{PEJ}$  (see 6);
- Notice that the occupation stems in (3) all contain an overt nominaliser, *lǎo*-, *-shǒu* and *-shēng*, so their incompatibility with -lǎo is expected;
- We attribute all the specifications in the objective meaning to  $n_{PEJ}$ , without positing separate layers like Gender°;
- We leave as an open question whether a verb-/ adjective-becoming stem that merges with -lǎo with is categorised. There is a similar problem one encounters when analysing compounds.

(6)  $nP$   
 $e \rightarrow t$   $(e \rightarrow t) \rightarrow e \rightarrow t \blacklozenge (e \rightarrow t) \rightarrow t$   
 $\checkmark$   $n_{PEJ}$   $-lǎo$

(7)  $\llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket = \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{obj} \blacklozenge \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{subj}$ , where  
 $\llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{obj} = \lambda P. \lambda x. \mathbf{R}(P)(x) \wedge \text{ADULT-MALE}(x);$   
 $\llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{subj} = \lambda P. \text{BAD}(\cap P).$

(8)  $\llbracket (2n^2) \rrbracket = \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket (\llbracket \text{finance} \rrbracket)$   
 $= \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{obj} (\llbracket \text{finance} \rrbracket) \blacklozenge \llbracket n_{PEJ} \rrbracket^{subj} (\llbracket \text{finance} \rrbracket)$   
 $= \lambda x. \text{DO}(\lambda y. \text{FINANCE}(y))(x) \wedge \text{ADULT-MALE}(x) \blacklozenge \text{BAD}(\cap \lambda y. \text{FINANCE}(y)).$

Semantics

- The semantics of  $n_{PEJ}$  is of mixed type (see MCCREADY 2019);
- $n_{PEJ}$  has two dimensions of contents, one objective and one subjective as seen in (7);
- The objective part (left to  $\blacklozenge$ ) takes a property  $P$  and an individual  $x$ , requiring that a pragmatically determined relation  $\mathbf{R}$  holds between  $P$  and  $x$ ;
- $\mathbf{R}$  can be BE, FROM, DO etc. (see INGASON & SIGURÐSSON 2020 i.a.);
- The subjective part (right to  $\blacklozenge$ ) takes a property  $P$  and returns  $\text{BAD}(\cap P)$  ( $\cap$  denotes the kind operator (CARLSON 1977, CHIERCHIA 1998)), where pejorative effects arise.

## Implications

- Mandarin -lǎo displays a clear case of *analytic pejorativity* as opposed to superficially monomorphemic pejoratives like *shrink*;
- Analytic pejorative affixes are also found in other languages, e.g. *-payng-* (뻥) in Korean;
- The study demonstrates the feasibility of a compositional analysis of pejorative expressions (for Potts in MCCREADY 2010 p. 10). It also provides a perspective on how discrimination can be linguistically represented in syntax and its interfaces with other modules.

## References

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Abbreviations: 1 = first person, CL = classifier, COP = copula, NAME = name, NEG = negative, NMLZ = nominalizer, PEJ = pejorative marker, SG = singular.  
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